

4 Early Grade Reading in Ethiopia

Phonological awareness in grade 1 textbook: the case of Koorete Language

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Introduction

Phonological awareness (PA) is a key component in developing children's literacy skills in early grades. It is the ability to recognize, reflect, and manipulate the sound structures of words regardless of their meaning. It is a broad umbrella concept that encompasses awareness of the phonological structure of spoken words, including rhyme, alliteration, words, syllables, onset rhyme, and phonemes (Cabell, Justice, Kaderavek, Turnbull, & Breit-Smith, 2009; NELP, 2008; Vloedgraven & Verhoeven, 2009). Existing research has shown that this is a strong predictor of their future reading ability. It also improves and accelerates early-stage reading learning (Milankov, Golubović, Krstić, & Golubović, 2021; Schuele & Boudreau, 2008; Phillips, Clancy-Menchetti, & Lonigan, 2008; Carson, Gillon, & Boustead, 2013).

In first grade, children should develop a full range of skills ranging from fewer complexes to more complex sequences of phonological awareness activities. The less complex components of phonological awareness include words into syllables, rhymes, and alliteration (e.g., initials and finals). The more complex sequences of phonological awareness activities include onset-rime segmentation, segmentation of initial and final sounds, a blending of sounds into words, segmentation of words into sounds, and phonemic manipulation (isolation, identity, categorization, blending, segmentation, deletion, addition, substitution) (National Reading Panel (US), National Institute of Child Health, & Human Development (US), 2000; Schuele & Boudreau, 2008; Costenaro & Pesce, 2012).

In particular, the content of preschool and early grade textbooks needs to include the key components of teaching phonological awareness to develop reading skills (i.e. listening, rhyming, blending, deleting/segmenting) (Skibbe, Gerde, Wright, & Samples-Steele, 2016:231). Similarly, longitudinal studies recommend that these skills should be integrated into early grade classroom curricula as they represent the most important aspects of developing children's reading literacy (National Reading Panel (US) et al., 2000;

Schuele & Boudreau, 2008). The key components of PA should be integrated into teachers' lessons and teachers should be aware and practice according to early grade curriculum to improve children's reading skills. However, several studies have shown that children in low- and middle-income countries, even by the end of primary school, do not develop basic reading skills (UNESCO, 2017a). In these countries, children in primary schools struggle to read even simple words. According to recent United Nations (UN) data, nine of ten children in sub-Saharan Africa lack basic reading skills. Similarly, in Central and South Asia, about 81% of children cannot read to a minimum level (UNESCO, 2017b). As a result, the poor countries' reading scores are generally low compared to the developed countries. On average, only 9% of children in rich countries cannot read by the age of 10. In developing countries, across all low- and middle-income countries, more than half of children by the age of 10 cannot read and understand simple text (World Bank, 2019).

Ethiopia is a multinational state residing in Africa in which approximately more than 80 languages are spoken by more than 100 million people of different ethnic groups. Since 1994, Ethiopian education and training policies have marked a turning point in the way over 36 native languages have been introduced as the medium of instruction or taught as a school subject in primary schools (Roadmap Ethiopia, 2018:14). Therefore, the implementation of a multilingual language policy has created a great opportunity for less advantageous languages and language groups in such a multilingual country. As a result, many native language groups have attempted to use their mother tongues as the language of instruction and as a subject in primary schools. Nevertheless, several challenges have been hampering the implementation of mother tongue practice in Ethiopian schools. These include a lack of research-based knowledge and application of teaching and learning methods, lack of access to effective teacher training, lack of supplementary reading material, and lack of native language experts in Ethiopian education in general and minority languages in particular. Because of these challenges, education in Ethiopian schools remains complex and requires further investigation and intervention.

Piper (2010) conducted the Early Grade Reading Assessment in seven Ethiopian languages that are more populated. The result of the early-childhood reading assessment in seven Ethiopian languages, namely Tigrinya, Afan Oromo, Amharic, Somali, Sidaamu Afoo, Wolaita, and Haddiyissa, showed that children are not able to reach the expected minimum learning skills in the second and third grades in Ethiopia (Piper 2010). The assessment focused on the students' understanding of phonological and phonemic awareness, phonics, vocabulary, word decoding skills, reading fluency, reading comprehension, and listening comprehension. The results of the assessment showed that many children are unable to read at the minimum level of expected learning ability set by the Ministry of Education. The result also indicated that 34% of the second graders could not read even a single word and 48% of the children could not understand a single question in their mother tongue (Piper 2010).

Based on the results, an intervention focused on the development of reading particularly (teacher training at both pre-service and in-service levels and preparation of the quality of reading materials), and so on was conducted. Next, procedural and other tools for teacher competence assessment and school competence assessment tools were developed. The designing, development, and implementation of a formative assessment system enable teachers to monitor and promote the reading competence of students in the early grades (USAID Ethiopia, 2014, 2016, 2018). However, the results of the Early Grade Reading Assessment showed that the students in Ethiopia were making progress in acquiring reading comprehension and the progress was slow. The percentage of students who performed at the upper benchmark levels over the years was 31.3% in 2014, 34.2% in 2016, and 32.4% in 2018. It can be observed that the differences in the reading achievements of students in Ethiopia were very little in the three studies assessing reading comprehension in the early grade class USAID Ethiopia (2014, 2016, 2018).

Moreover, the most recent results showed that 6.2% of Ethiopian students in grades 2 and 3 and across all languages achieved the target reading benchmark, that is, reading fluently with complete or almost complete comprehension (USAID Ethiopia, 2018). The study found that nearly more than 80% of children in early grade have reading comprehension difficulties and are at risk of falling behind in their early grade reading achievement. The final report of the Early Grade Reading Assessment (EGRA) in Ethiopia by USAID Ethiopia (2018) showed that only 20% of children achieved a passing mark on reading comprehension questions, which is very low at the national level. In developing countries, in particular, the textbook is used as the main source during the classroom practice of teaching reading in the early grades; they still play a dominant role in many countries (Reichenberg, 2016). Therefore, evaluating the quality of the content of students' textbooks in alignment with the mother tongue's primary education curriculum and inquiry-based knowledge helps improve early grade reading achievement.

Children's inability to read a specific text limits the knowledge they acquire about the sound system; as a result, the children lack the knowledge to process and understand texts. As mentioned in the previous section, Early Grade Reading Assessment and Intervention have been used in Ethiopia for ten years since 2010 G.C. The results indicated that at an aggregated national level, overall reading performance changed little across the three Early Grade Reading Assessment End line reports (USAID Ethiopia, 2018). This result stated that reading achievement in elementary school classes in Ethiopia is not showing the progress one would hope for, considering several years of reading intervention. The majority of students had serious problems with letter identification, understanding phonological patterns, dealing with new words in the text, and understanding longer texts (Anteneh et al., 2016:17).

In Ethiopia, the primary school curriculum promotes the first language as the medium of instruction in primary schools, and several mother tongues use their first languages as the language of instruction in various minority

language groups. However, these minority languages are becoming increasingly popular due to deficits in raising awareness, adequate teacher training, the suitability of the languages in terms of orthography and scientific terminology as a medium of instruction, the availability and quality of teaching and learning materials, standard orthography of guidelines, and a strategy for delivering the mother tongue educational program, support, and follow-up of the implementation of mother tongue teaching (Mesfin, 2020:164). On the other hand, the language development of a native speaker in a country varies greatly from language to language and requires language-specific support. Development depends on language policies, the curriculum, the quality of teacher education, the literacy environment, language experts and the quality of textbooks and teacher's guides, and home literacy. In this direction, no opportunity for further scientific research and interventions to develop reading literacy is given to beginners and less preferred languages like Koorete.

Studies have found that the quality of textbooks and curriculum plays an important role in early grade reading achievement, particularly in developing countries that lack access to local literacy materials. Textbooks play a crucial role in many language classes and are considered the second most important factor in language teaching after teachers, for they serve not only as teaching materials but also as supplementary materials by incorporating definitions of the terms and the results of many different types of research (Riazi, 2003; Zemenu, 2013). In the Ethiopian context, where there are not enough teaching materials, textbooks are seen as the basic sources of ideas and information (Zemenu, 2013:45). A review of the recent literature on the use of textbooks in language teaching shows that textbook has become the central important tool in schools as it prescribes implicit and explicit tasks that define the core work of schools (Wen-Cheng, Chien-Hung, & Chung-Chieh, 2011:92). Similarly, Dalim and Mubarrak (2013) noted that textbooks are used as the main source of information when teaching a particular subject and that the quality and accuracy of the content are critical to their pedagogical effectiveness.

The quality of textbooks should be assessed and evaluated during implementation by external consultants who were not involved in the textbook development and selection process (USAID Ethiopia, 2016). This paper aims to evaluate the adequacy of the content of the first-grade textbook in terms of components of phonological awareness in Koorete in the context of primary education in Ethiopia. It assesses the alignment of the textbook with the Ministry of Education's mother tongue syllabus (MOE Ethiopia, 2013) and with research-based early school literature on the components of phonological awareness (National Reading Panel (US) et al., 2000; Schuele & Boudreau, 2008). Evaluating the content of textbooks for primary school classes in terms of phonological awareness is very important to appraise the content alignment towards mother-tongue primary school education curriculum, literature-based knowledge in the teaching of reading skills, and to recommend possible measures to improve the quality of the textbook.

This paper aimed to evaluate the alignment of the textbook with the Ministry of Education's mother tongue syllabus (MoE Ethiopia, 2013) and with research-based early school literature on the components of phonological awareness (National Reading Panel (US) et al., 2000; Schuele & Boudreau, 2008).

Theoretical framework

The development of early grade literacy is the basic foundation for later children's academic achievement which has multiple theoretical frameworks related to literacy learning in early grade. The theoretical frameworks that frame this study employ Vygotsky's theory of social constructivism (1978). According to a social constructivist perspective, knowledge is constructed by individuals, groups, and society and not simply transferred. The main concepts of the theoretical framework that emerge from the mediation process, in particular, are the key concepts of the zone of proximal development (ZPD) and their direct implications for the process of teaching and learning phonological awareness. In this way, mediation is one of the key crucial concepts in social constructivism theory.

In addition, the sociocultural language learning theory claims that language cannot be learned in its isolation rather it is a social effort in its substance it needs to be learned in a social context with the help of peers, parents, teachers, and so forth (Zuengler & Miller, 2006; Vygotsky, 1978). It describes learning and development as being embedded within social events and occurring as a learner interacts with other people, objects, and events in the collaborative environment (Vygotsky, 1978). The relationship between the social world and cognitive development of the sociocultural theory of learning is the understanding of the relation between the social world and cognitive development. The underlying themes of sociocultural theory on cognitive development have thus often been summarized as the significance of culture, the role of a principal proponent of culture and language, and the student's relationship with and development within this sociocultural world. In this context, culture is viewed as socially accepted behaviors, attitudes, and beliefs. It is constructed through human societal products such as institutions, symbol systems, and tools such as language (Zhou & Brown, 2017).

A sociocultural perspective emphasizes that infants experience, participate in, and develop literacy knowledge, attitudes, and skills as they, directly and indirectly, take part in literacy practices within various social and cultural contexts (Hamer, 2005). By viewing infants as active literacy participants and learners, educators can provide opportunities for infants to take part in a wide range of relevant, purposeful, and contextually meaningful literacy practices. The social process also recognizes the important role of a teacher as a mediator or facilitator who should help learners develop their reading skills by working with the teacher and peers and later being able to work alone. This is what other scholars call 'scaffolding the learners', which means giving learners help

only when they need it and withdrawing it once they can work on their own (Bauman-Barton, 2001; Enyew & Yigzaw, 2015; Fottland & Matre, 2005; Vygotsky, 1978).

This study was conducted to evaluate the content alignment of students' textbooks with the primary school curriculum with phonological awareness in the first-grade Koorete Language in Ethiopia. Alignment refers to the degree to which the elementary school language textbook and relevant syllabuses match to achieve the specified minimum learning competency at the level. Accordingly, in this study, the alignment of early Koorete Language textbooks with their corresponding curricula on the components of phonological awareness was evaluated by adopting the frameworks given in MoE Ethiopia (2013) and Schuele and Boudreau (2008). Well-designed curriculum and textbook alignment play a central role in the quality of early grade instruction (Biggs & Tang, 2011). Poor alignment of curriculum materials and their components leads to disagreement, confusion, and poor learning outcomes for students (Stabback, 2016). This demonstrates how early graduate materials and the quality of curriculum delivery contribute to early grade learning.

Method

This chapter aims to evaluate the alignment of the first-grade Koorete Language textbook with the corresponding mother tongue language primary school syllabus. To this end, the following content analysis checklist was used to evaluate the alignment of the content of the grade 1 textbook with its corresponding syllabus about phonological awareness in the Koorete Language. The quality of the description of the textbook was also assessed in line with the early grade reading literature. The key components of the phonological awareness lessons were adopted from the syllabus of primary education in Ethiopia prepared by the Ministry of Education (MoE Ethiopia, 2013) and the early grade reading literature from Schuele and Boudreau (2008) as can be seen in Table 4.1.

Design

This study used a qualitative content analysis method inspired by a case study to evaluate the alignment of a grade 1 mother tongue textbook with the corresponding syllabus in terms of the components of phonological awareness. Qualitative content analysis is a systematic, repeatable technique that groups specific words of a text with smaller content categories using codes based on specific rules (Delve & Limpacher, 2023). In this study, descriptive content analysis was employed as it has a systematic analysis, involving the discussion of specific textbook content in a descriptive assessment (Sozbilir, Kutu, & Yasar, 2012). In addition, a purposive sampling technique was used to select the grade level, textbook, and textbook content, since the analysis focused on a specific aspect of teaching throughout the units. The data were coded, organized, and trans-themed according to the components of phonological

Table 4.1 The components of phonological awareness activities

<i>Stages</i>	<i>Type</i>	<i>Description</i>	<i>Example (answer)</i>
Words into syllable	Isolation	Given a word, children recognize the first syllable in a word	Tell me the first syllable in 'forget'. (for)
	Blending	A broken word is given in syllables and combines the word parts to create the word.	What word is, /'ex/- /er/- /cise/? (exercise)
	Deletion	Omitting part of a multisyllabic word, to create a new word	What is 'teacher' without /er /? (teach)
	Segmentation	Breaking the given compound words into two smaller words.	Sound out (clap hands; tap knee; count on fingers) the number of syllables in the word 'remember'. (re/mem/ber, = 3 syllables)
Rhyme	Identity recognition	Recognize & generate familiar rhyme pairs in a familiar context. Recognize & generate familiar rhyme pairs in an unfamiliar context.	Tell me which two words are among these rhymes. 'Forget, remember, bet' (bet) Rhyme such as bat, cat, mat
	Production	Given a word, the student says a word that rhymes.	Which one sounds different – jug, ram, bug?
Alliteration	Initial & final sound sorts	Recognize and play with the same first sounds in words	What is the first sound of the words? (e.g., <i>a big burly black bear</i>)
Onset and Rime	Onset Unit:	The initial consonant or consonant cluster	Which one sounds different – jug, ram, bug? What is the initial sound? (e.g., <i>b + ug, st + op</i>).
	Rime Unit:	The medial vowel and its final consonant or consonant cluster	What are the medial vowel and final consonants? (e.g., <i>-up, -at, -ops</i>)
Phonemes (narrow tasks)	Isolation	Given a word, the student recognizes individual sounds in the word.	What is the first sound in /mat/? /m/ What is the last sound in /cat/? /t/
	Identification	The ability to identify the phoneme of a word	What sound is the same in the word let, love & lap? e.g., /l/
	Categorization	Given a set of three or four words, the student recognizes the word that has the 'odd' sound.	Which word does not belong: /bus/, /ball/, and /mouse/? (mouse)

(Continued)

Table 4.1 (Continued)

<i>Stages</i>	<i>Type</i>	<i>Description</i>	<i>Example (answer)</i>
	Blending	Given individual sounds of a word, children combine to form a word.	What word is, /f/- /i/- /f /- /t /- /i/? (fifty)
	Segmentation	Given a whole word, children break a word into separate sounds.	(e.g., <i>Tell me all the sounds you hear in a cat:</i> / k / + / æ / + / t /). /3/
	deletion	Recognizing the word that remains when a letter is removed.	What is 'train' without /t /? (rain)
	Addition	Given a word, the student makes a new word by adding a phoneme.	What word do you have if you add /s/ to the beginning of /park/? (spark)
	Substitution	Recognizing the word that remains when a letter is removed. What is 'train' without /t/? (rain)	The word is a rug. Change /g/ to /n/. What is the new word? (run)

awareness and analyzed accordingly (Wong, 2008). The qualitative case study design is deemed appropriate in this chapter because the major essence of this research is to assess the extent to which the student's textbook is consistent with the curriculum and the literature related to phonological awareness.

In qualitative research data, trustworthiness and credibility are key issues, so in building trustworthiness in this research, the researcher has provided a set of evidence by giving some general lesson content and pictures in the textbook analysis (see Figures 4.1, 4.2, and 4.3) and referring as well as relating these lessons and images with the material being assessed. Besides, to ensure the validity of the data collection tools, the content of PA was extracted from the curriculum of the native language primary education in Ethiopia, that is, MoE Ethiopia (2013) and the early grade reading literature review from National Reading Panel (US) et al. (2000) and Schuele and Boudreau (2008). The tools were then piloted and the results of the analysis were presented in a seminar.

The method of content analysis involves collecting similar data within the framework of certain concepts and themes and organizing and interpreting them in an order that the reader can think of, as well as an in-depth description and explanation of the questions to be examined (Macnamara, 2018). Krippendorff (2004:18) also defines content analysis as a research technique for drawing reproducible and valid conclusions from texts about the contexts of their use. It is the intellectual process of categorizing qualitative textual data

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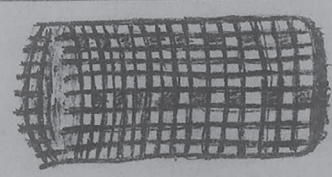
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d	 dado	dado da d
u	 usume	usume Su S
u	 suma	suma Su u

Figure 4.1 Extracted lesson from unit 1

into clusters of similar units or conceptual categories to identify consistent patterns and relationships between variables or themes. The content analysis protocol was developed by reviewing the first-grade native language primary school curriculum as given in MoE Ethiopia (2013) and the related literature on teaching the key components of phonological awareness in early grades in

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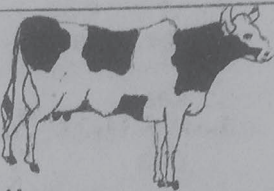
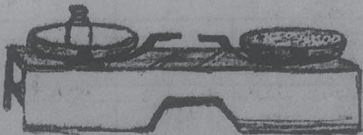
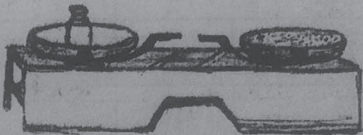
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ii		kiilo kii ii

Figure 4.2 Extracted lesson from unit 3

the following works: National Reading Panel (US) et al. (2000) and Schuele and Boudreau (2008).

Qualitative content analysis is one of the research methods for analyzing text data. Typically, a study using a summative approach to qualitative content analysis begins by identifying and quantifying specific words or content in the text to understand the contextual use of the words or content. This

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xh		gulxhe xhe xh
	gulxhe	

Figure 4.3 Extracted lesson from unit 5

quantification is an attempt not to infer meaning, but rather to examine usage. Analysis of the occurrence of a specific word or content in textual material is called manifest content analysis (Potter & Levine-Donnerstein, 1999). Summative content analysis involves counting and comparing, usually keywords or content, followed by interpreting the underlying context as is shown in

Hsieh and Shannon (2005). On the other hand, thematic analysis is a method for systematically identifying, organizing and providing insights into patterns of meaning (themes) in a dataset. By focusing on the meaning of a dataset, thematic analysis allows the researcher to see and understand collective or shared meanings and experiences. The identification of unique and idiosyncratic meanings and experiences found only in a single data item is not the focus of the thematic analysis.

Thematic content analysis helps to synthesize and interpret a specific topic from a critical perspective by developing themes. Therefore, based on the objectives of the study, a guiding criterion based on the curriculum of the Ministry of Education, Ethiopia, and the literature on the components of phonological awareness in the first grade was adapted to determine the quality of the textbook and to assess whether the textbook meets the requirements in the literature. Accordingly, descriptive content analysis was employed to examine the components of phonological awareness activities in the textbooks of first-grade students in the Koorete Language. Accordingly, using a content analysis checklist the data were coded, organized, transcribed, and analyzed thematically according to the criteria. To collect data, the researcher used a content analysis checklist and document analysis.

To analyze the data, the researcher used both frequency and percentage simple statistics to determine what percentage of the key components of phonological awareness have been emphasized by the existing first-grade Koorete Language textbook. In addition, an in-depth evaluation of the alignment of the textbook with the corresponding curriculum was carried out. For this effect, five main components and 18 sub-components were used as units of analysis for the study. Finally, based on the findings, interpretation, and discussion of the results, as well as, conclusion and recommendations would be proposed.

This research was conducted in the Koorete Language of the first-grade textbook in Amaro Special Woreda in Southern Nations and Nationalities Peoples Regional State (SNNPRS). The textbook introduced four levels of reading activity, namely sound-level activity, syllable-level activity, word-level activity, and sentence-level activity. The first three reading activities were intentionally chosen throughout the units as they are related to phonological awareness activities, which are the basis for analysis. The data were collected through interviews and content analysis based on the content analysis protocol given in Table 4.2. The content analysis protocol was adapted from the mother tongue syllabus for primary education in Ethiopia prepared by the Ethiopian Ministry of Education in 2013 and from the early grade literature given in NRP (2000) and Schuele and Boudreau (2008). To ensure the external and content validity of the tools, a pilot study was carried out, and the results of the data were presented in a seminar organized by the NORAD project and Addis Ababa University.

Table 4.2 A protocol of content alignment between syllabus and textbook

Themes	Components of phonological awareness			
	in syllabus & literature	in textbook		
		yes	no	reflection
syllable	isolation blending deletion segmentation			
rhyme	identity recognition production			
alliteration	initial & final sound			
onset-rime	isolation identification categorization			
phoneme	isolation blending identity segmentation deletion addition substitution			

Materials

The first-grade textbook was chosen for investigation because it is the only resource used in the first grade to teach the Koorete Language according to the Ethiopian Primary School Curriculum for grades 1–4 (see MoE Ethiopia, 2013). The textbook was developed in 2000 by a group of native Koorete-speaking scholars with diverse academic backgrounds. An officer from Amaro Special Woreda Education Office coordinated the process. It was revised in 2012 G.C. by selected language teachers coordinated by the Woreda Education Office. The textbook is divided into 7 units and has 94 pages. Each unit is integrated with different language lessons, namely speaking, listening, reading, and writing. For this study, only reading instruction was focused across all the units. Specifically, this research focused on evaluating the alignment of the syllabus of mother tongue language in primary education with the contents of the first-grade textbook concerning phonological awareness, which is a core component of reading instruction.

Procedures of data collection

The procedure of data collection in this work follows the practice proposed by Ur (2009:185–187), which comprises three steps: criteria definition, criteria

application, and summary. In establishing the criteria, the components of phonological awareness in the literature were considered using the works of the National Reading Panel (US) et al. (2000) as well as Schuele and Boudreau (2008), and then the researcher adopted the checklist. Next, based on the criteria, a description based on key components of the phonological awareness activities was set, and then the textbook for first-grade students was evaluated accordingly.

The components of phonological awareness were coded thematically based on the syllabus and literature of early grade, then the selected content of the textbook was presented through the units for interpretation and analysis. Then the obtained data from content analysis were categorized, transcribed, translated, organized, and analyzed according to the theme. Finally, in the summary step, conclusions were drawn based on the ratings and descriptions. Then, an overall evaluation of the first-grade textbook was made.

Coding

Qualitative content analysis has been defined as a research method for subjectively interpreting the content of textual data through the systematic classification process of coding and identifying themes or patterns (Hsieh & Shannon, 2005:1278). Therefore, primary school home language curricula and the available literature especially on the key components of phonological awareness were used to encode the specific content of the textbook for further analysis.

The components of PA activities were coded into five themes: words into syllables (isolation, blending, deletion, segmentation); rhyme (identity, production); onset and rime (isolation, categorization); alliteration (sorting initial and final sounds); phoneme manipulation (identifies, isolate, categorize, blend, segment, delete, add and replace) based on the works in MoE Ethiopia (2013), NRP (2000), and Schuele and Boudreau (2008). On this basis, observation checklists were created. The contents of the textbook were coded based on the content analysis framework given by Krippendorff (2013).

The unique facets of the method of qualitative content analysis were taken into account (Forman & Damschroder, 2008; Zhang & Wildemuth, 2009), which includes careful consideration of the following: first, credibility issues, such as the content sample (if required), the selected unit of analysis, the code development, and the coding process; second, analysability processes, such as filling out and checking auxiliary materials, for example, coding forms and the identification of categories and topics; three, transparency in the final document and inclusion of important details related to the conception and implementation of the method of qualitative content analysis and the interpretation of qualitative content analysis data.

Results

The results of the data analysis were divided into five themes: syllable activities (isolation, blending, deletion, and segmentation); rhyming activities (identity,

recognition, and production); alliteration (initial and final sounds); onset rhyme identification; and phoneme manipulation (isolation, identity, categorization, blending, segmentation, deletion, addition, and substitution). The content analysis was analyzed in two sections: evaluation of the frequency and description of the selected lessons about their content quality and relevance according to the syllabus of primary education. The qualitative method extracted representative lessons from units 1, 3, and 5, which resulted from the qualitative data analysis, and was organized into word, syllable, and sound-level activities to assess the adequacy of the contents. In the following sections, the frequency and percentage of occurrence of the components of phonological awareness across the chapter have been presented.

Description of the frequency of the components of phonological awareness

Words into syllables activities

This section evaluates the occurrence of the components of phonological awareness lessons across the units: words into syllables. In particular, word-to-syllable activities include syllable (isolation, blending, deletion, and segmentation) activities. The frequency (f) of the components of phonological awareness of the distribution through the units is presented. The result of the contents distribution across the units is presented in the following section (see Table 4.3).

In the table above, the occurrence of the lessons is summarized in terms of their frequency and percentages. Syllable isolation activities were found in all units via words in the syllable phase. Accordingly, unit 1 has 4 (13.8%) lessons; units 2, 4 (13.8%) lessons; units 3, 6 (20%) lessons; units 4, 3 (10.3%) lessons; and units 5, 6, and 7, contain 1 (3.4%) each. The results of the syllable segmentation per unit are similar in frequency and percentage to syllable isolation (see Table 4.3).

Other activities: rhyming, alliteration, and onset-rime

Other activities of phonological awareness like rhyming activities (identity, blending, and production); alliteration (initial and final sound); and onset-rime identification activities are not integrated through the units as can be seen from Table 4.4.

Table 4.3 Total distribution of words into syllable activities across the units

Syllable	unit 1		unit 2		unit 3		unit 4		unit 5		unit 6		unit 7	
	f	%	f	%	f	%	F	%	f	%	f	%	f	%
isolation	4	13.8	4	13.8	6	20	3	10.3	1	3.4	1	3.4	1	3.4
segmentation	4	13.8	4	13.8	6	20	3	10.3	1	3.4	1	3.4	1	3.4

Table 4.4 Distribution of phoneme manipulation across the units

<i>phoneme</i>	<i>unit 1</i>		<i>unit 2</i>		<i>unit 3</i>		<i>unit 4</i>		<i>unit 5</i>		<i>unit 6</i>		<i>unit 7</i>	
	<i>f</i>	<i>%</i>	<i>f</i>	<i>%</i>	<i>f</i>	<i>%</i>	<i>f</i>	<i>%</i>	<i>f</i>	<i>%</i>	<i>f</i>	<i>%</i>	<i>f</i>	<i>%</i>
isolation	3	10.3	4	13.8	5	17.4	4	13.8	7	24.1	5	17.2	1	3.4
identity	3	10.3	4	13.8	5	17.4	4	13.8	7	24.1	5	17.2	1	3.4
segmentation	4	13.8	4	13.8	5	17.2	3	10.3	7	24.1	5	17.2	1	3.4

Phoneme manipulation

Phoneme manipulation is another component of phonological awareness. Phoneme manipulation activities include phonemes (isolation, identity, categorization, blending, segmentation, deletion, addition, and substitution). The following section presents the occurrences of phoneme manipulation activities (isolation, identity, and segmentation) lessons in the units of the textbook under consideration.

In the table above, the occurrences of the phoneme isolation lessons in terms of their frequency and percentage are unit 1, 3 (10.3%) lessons; unit 2, 4 (13.8%) lessons; units 3, 5 (17.4%) lessons; unit 4, 4 (13.8%) lessons; unit 5, 7 (24.1%) lessons; unit 6, 5 (17.2%) lessons; and unit 7, 1 (3.4%) lesson are presented as can be seen from Table 4.4.

In addition, the occurrence of phoneme identity lessons is: unit 1, 3 (10.3%) lessons; unit 2, 4 (13.8%) lessons; units 3, 5 (17.4%) lessons; unit 4, 4 (13.8%) lessons; unit 5, 7 (24.1%) lessons; unit 6, 5 (17.2%) lessons; and unit 7, 1 (3.4%) lesson is presented (see Table 4.4).

The occurrences of phoneme segmentations lessons activities in unit 1 are 4 (13.8%) lessons; unit 2, 4 (13.8%) lessons; units 3, 5 (17.2%) lessons; unit 4, 3 (10.3%) lessons; unit 5, 7 (24.1%) lessons; unit 6, 5 (17.2%) lessons; and unit 7, 1 (3.4%) lesson are presented as can be seen from Table 4.4.

Table 4.5 shows the absence of some components of phonological awareness activities across the observed units in the textbook. The lessons, which were not integrated with phonological awareness activities in the different units of the textbook, are shown as 0% in the table (see Table 4.5).

As can be observed in the table, syllable (blending, deleting); rhyming (recognition, production); alliteration (initial and final sounds); and onset-rime activities were not made parts of the units of the textbook. Similarly, phoneme manipulation, namely phoneme categorization, blending, deletion, addition, and substitution, was not integrated across the units observed (see Table 4.5).

Content relevance concerning the syllabus

Three lessons were extracted from the textbook to evaluate the appropriateness of the textbook in following what is encapsulated in the syllabus. Because the textbook content contains the same lesson presentations in all of the units,

Table 4.5 Distribution of phonological awareness activities across the units

Components of phonological awareness		Lesson frequency and percentage	
		Freq.	Perc. (%)
Syllables	blending	0	0
	deletion	0	0
Rhyme	identity	0	0
	recognition	0	0
Alliteration	production	0	0
	initial sound	0	0
	final sound	0	0
Onset-rime	identification	0	0
Phoneme	categorization	0	0
	blend	0	0
	deletion	0	0
	addition	0	0
	substitution	0	0

Table 4.6 Alignment of words into syllables in the G1 textbook and the syllabus

Theme	Components of phonological awareness			
	In the syllabus & literature	In textbook		
		Yes	No	reflection
Syllable	isolation	yes		inappropriate
	segmentation	yes		inappropriate
	blending		no	omitted
	deletion		no	omitted

the researcher purposely selected only three representative lessons from units 1, 3, and 5 out of the 7 units (see Figures 4.1, 4.2, and 4.3).

In the extracted lesson, each word is syllabified as, *maido* ‘ox’ (*do, d*), *dada* ‘lightning’ (*da, d*), *usume* ‘storage’ (*su, u*), and *suma* ‘door’ (*su, u*) (see Figure 4.1.). This includes the word, the syllable with the focused letter like *do*, *da*-, and *su*-, and the sounds like /d/, /s/, & /u/ as shown earlier. It is also shown that words like *maido* ‘ox’ have been segmented into *do*, and *dado* ‘detainment’ into *do*, whereas items like *usume* ‘storage’ and *suma* ‘door’, have been presented in the lesson being segmented into *su* and *su* respectively.

The result of the textbook’s content alignment with the syllabus in terms of word-in-syllable activities, such as isolation, segmentation, merging, and deletion, is presented in Table 4.6.

In **syllables isolation**, in unit 1, page 8, words are syllabified as *maido* ‘ox’ (*do, d*), *dada* ‘lightning’ (*da, d*), *usume* ‘storage’ (*su, u*), and *suma* ‘door’ (*su, u*);

in unit 3, page 32, words are presented as *miise* ‘cow’ (*mii, ii*), *siila* ‘seedling of enset’ (*sii, ii*), *tiire* ‘squatting’ (*tii, ii*), and *kiilo* ‘kilo’ (*kii, ii*); and in unit 5, page 70, words are exhibited as *xhaqo* ‘locust’ (*xba, xb*), *xbilo* ‘eagle’ (*xbi, xb*), and *gulxhe* ‘fish’ (*xhe, xb*). The textbook also presented the only syllable with the given sound; ‘do’, *da, su, mii, sii, tii, kii, xba, xhe, xbi*, and so on. However, in the given words, other syllables that can be used for further practice are not presented in the textbook.

In **syllables segmentation**, in unit 1, page 8, the word *maido* ‘ox’ are segmented a (*do, d*), *dada* ‘lightning’ (*da, d*), *usume* ‘storage’ (*su, u*), and *suma* ‘door’ (*su, u*); in unit 3, page 32, words are segmented like *miise* ‘cow’ (*mii, se*), *siila* ‘seedling of enset’ (*sii, la*), *tiire* ‘squatting’ (*tii, re*), and *kilo* ‘kilo’ (*kii, lo*); and in unit 5, page 70, words are segmented like ‘*xhaqo*’ (*xba, xb*), ‘*xbelbe*’ (*xhe, xb*), ‘*xbilo*’ (*xbi, xb*), and ‘*gulxhe*’ (*xhe, xb*).

Other syllables in the given words are not segmented, as indicated both in the syllabus and in the available literature. On the other hand, it was found that **syllable blending and syllable deletion** were not integrated into the textbook (see Table 4.6).

The extracted lesson on the components of phonological awareness is presented in Figure 4.2 for further analysis.

The lesson in unit 3, taken from page 31, deals with syllable isolation; these are *miise* ‘cow’ (*mii, se*), *siila* ‘seedling of enset’ (*sii, la*), *tiire* ‘squatting’ (*tii, re*), and *kiilo* ‘kilo’ (*kii, lo*). This includes the word, the syllable with the focused letter like *mii, sii, tii*, and *kii*. Besides, in the textbook the words like *miise* ‘cow’ is segmented into *mii*, *siila* ‘seedling of enset’ into *sii*, *tiire* ‘squatting’ into *tii*, and *kilo* ‘kilo’ into *kii*. The vowel /ii/ is also represented in the given words and syllables as can be seen in Figure 4.2. The results of the matching of rhyming activity and alliteration against the textbook and the syllabus are presented in Table 4.7.

Rhyme activities like rhyme (identity, recognition, and production) were not integrated into the contents of a textbook (Table 4.7). Similarly, as seen in the rest of the chapters, **alliteration** (initial and final sounds) activities were not made part of the textbook. The extracted lesson on the components of phonological awareness is presented in Figure 4.3 for further analysis.

Table 4.7 Alignment of rhyme activity and alliteration between textbook and syllabus

Theme	Components of phonological awareness			
	In the syllabus & literature	In textbook		
		Yes	No	reflection
Rhyme	identity		no	omitted
	recognition		no	omitted
	production		no	omitted
Alliteration	initial and final sounds		no	omitted

Table 4.8 Alignment of onset and rime between curriculum and textbook

Theme	Components of phonological awareness			
	In the syllabus & literature	In textbook		
		Yes	No	reflection
Onset-rime	isolation		no	omitted
	identification		no	omitted
	categorization		no	omitted

Table 4.9 Alignment of phoneme manipulation between curriculum and textbook

Theme	Components of phonological awareness			
	In the syllabus & literature	In textbook		
		Yes	No	reflection
Phoneme	isolation	yes		incomplete
	identification	yes		incomplete
	segmentation	yes		incomplete
	categorization		no	omitted
	blending		no	omitted
	deletion		no	omitted
	addition		no	omitted
	Substitution		no	omitted

In unit 5, page 70, lessons on words, syllables, and sounds were also presented. The lessons are *xhaqo* ‘locust’ (*xha*, *xh*), *xhilo* ‘eagle’ (*xhi*, *xh*), and *gulxhe* ‘fish’ (*xhe*, *xh*), which represented the syllables with the focused letters, that is, *xha*, *xhe*, and *xhi*. In addition, the words *xhaqo*, *xhilo*, and *gulxhe* were found to be broken down into *xha*, *xhii*, and *xhe* syllables respectively (see Figure 4.3). In this section, the grapheme /*xh*/ is represented both in words and syllables (see Figure 4.3). In addition, the results of the textbook-syllabus content alignment on the onset and rhyming activities are provided in Table 4.8.

Table 4.8 shows that onset and rime activities – isolation, identification, and categorization – were not integrated into the students’ textbook contrary to the syllabus. The results of the evaluation of the contents of the textbook with the corresponding syllabus in terms of phoneme manipulation are summarized in Table 4.9.

This study found that **phoneme-identifying** lessons were incorporated into the textbook under consideration. For instance, the phoneme /*d*/ was presented in the words *maid*o ‘ox’ and *dada* ‘lightning’, and /*u*/ was the other phoneme identified in the words *usume* and *suma* respectively as given in Figure 4.1.

The phoneme /*ii*/ was found to be presented in the words *miise* ‘cow’, *siila* ‘seedling of enset’, and *tiire* ‘squatting’ as in Figure 4.2. Similarly, the phoneme /*xh*/ was identified as being presented in the words: *xhaqo* ‘locust’,

xbilo ‘eagle’, and *gulxhe* ‘fish’ (see Figure 4.3). This phoneme was given in different words so that it would be possible to identify similar phonemes from different words.

Moreover, in the **phoneme isolation** lesson, the textbook presented a given phoneme in a manner to help the children recognize individual sounds. Some of such phonemes that appeared in the lesson include /d/, /s/, /u/, /ii/, and /xh/ (see Figures 4.1, 4.2, and 4.3).

In the extracted lessons from the different chapters observed **phoneme segmentation** activities were made an integral part of the lesson. In the different sections of the lessons, for instance, *maido* ‘ox’ was segmented into (*do, d*), *usume* ‘storage’ into (*su, u*), *miise* ‘cow’ into (*mii, se*), *siila* ‘seedling of enset’ into (*sii, la*), *xhaqo* ‘locust’ into (*xha, xh*), and *gulxhe* ‘fish’ into (*gul, xhe*). They were not, however, appropriately stated according to the early-grade literature.

A gap was observed in the textbook regarding **phoneme segmentation**. In the words given in the textbook, individual sounds should have been segmented. That is, the word *maido* ‘ox’ has been segmented as /m/ + /ai/ + /d/ + /o/; the word *miise* ‘cow’ as /m/ + /ii/ + /s/ + /e/; and *xhaq* ‘locust’ as /xh/ + /a/ + /q/ + /o/ (cf. Figures 4.1, 4.2, and 4.3). This implied the presence of an **incomplete description** of phoneme segmentation in the textbook, especially when its alignment with the syllabus and the literature is considered. Another observation also indicated that the extracted lessons from the textbook did not integrate the phoneme (**blending, deletion, addition, and substitution**) activities across the chapters according to the syllabus and early grade literature. Such lessons were entirely omitted from the textbook.

Discussion

Textbooks are the main educational materials used in Ethiopian schools for teaching and learning activities (Setegn, 2021), and aligning textbooks with the appropriate curriculum helps improve student learning in a given subject (Hadar, 2017). In the study, evaluating contents of the selected textbook regarding the components of phonological awareness was made based on the protocol adapted from the mother language curriculum for primary education in Ethiopia and early grade literature as given in the following works: MoE Ethiopia (2013), National Reading Panel (US) et al. (2000), and Schuele and Boudreau (2008). The results of the textbook evaluation showed the presence of gaps in three areas across units. These are (1) inappropriateness, (2) incomplete description, and (3) omission of components of phonological awareness. A discussion of each of these gaps is presented here.

Inadequacy of the components of phonological awareness

Two components have been introduced in word-to-syllable activities: syllable isolation and syllable segmentation. Content inadequacies in syllable isolation

were counted for a maximum of 20% of lessons presented across the units. With syllable segmentation, a similar percentage of lessons were integrated through the units. As the data analysis showed in each unit the number of lesson presentations was too low; for example, in unit five, the reported lessons were only 3.4%. This result indicates that the phonological awareness components of syllable isolation and syllable segmentation are inadequate lessons in the first-grade textbook.

Regarding phoneme manipulation, most of its components were not adequately integrated into the units of the student textbook. For example, in the case of phoneme isolation, a maximum of 24.1% of lessons were shown in unit 5, whereas the minimum number of lessons was observed in unit 7, which was 3.4%. In addition, in terms of phoneme identity and phoneme segmentation, an almost similar percentage was obtained for the lessons (see Table 4.3). The result shows that the content of the first-grade textbook failed to present adequate lessons throughout the units to help children learn to read.

Inappropriate presentation of the lessons

In **syllables isolation**, the textbook presented words by syllabifying them as *maido* ‘ox’ (*do, d*), *miise* ‘cow’ (*mii, ii*), and *xhaqo* ‘locust’ (*xha, xh*). That means, the textbook tried to present a single syllable from the given word, other syllables are not mentioned as these syllables /*do*/, /*mii*/, and /*xha*/ occurred in the above words. The correct syllable isolation would be *maido* ‘ox’ (*mai-do*), *miise* (*mii-se*), and *xhaqo* (*xha-qo*), and so on, but as the analysis showed, the lessons did not present to the children in a manner that helps them practice each syllable.

In **syllables segmentation**, in the textbook words were segmented as follows: *maido* ‘ox’ (*do, d*), *usume* ‘storage’ (*su, u*), *miise* ‘cow’ (*mii, se*), and *xhaqo* ‘locust’ (*xha, xh*), etc. The correct way of segmenting these syllables would be, for example, *maido* ‘ox’ as (*mai-do*), *usume* ‘storage’ (*u-su-me*), *miise* ‘cow’ as (*mii-se*), and *xhaqo* ‘locust’ as (*xha-qo*) (cf. Figure 4.1, 4.2, and 4.3). In the textbook, the **syllable segmentation** focused only on a syllable with a given sound, but the rest of the syllables in the words under consideration were not given. This shows that syllable segmentation is inappropriately treated. Generally, the words in the textbook were not syllabified according to what was set out in the curriculum and given in the established literature (MoE Ethiopia, 2013; NRP, 2000; Schuele & Boudreau, 2008).

The incorporation of words into syllabic awareness includes activities such as joining a word into a syllable as in the items *pen-cil* to form the word pencil and **syllable segmentation**, counting the syllables in the word and pronouncing the syllables separately (Bauman-Wängler, 2009; Yule, 2006).

In the **phoneme segmentation** section words are segmented accordingly: for instance, *maido* ‘ox’ into (*do, d*); *miise* ‘cow’ into (*mii, ii*); and *xhaqo* ‘locust’ into (*xha, xh*), etc. As it was observed in the textbook, these words

were not syllabified into individual sounds. For instance, *maido* ‘ox’ was not segmented into /m/ /ai/ /d/ /o/; *miise* ‘cow’ was not syllabified as /m/ /ii/ /s/ /e/ and *xbago* ‘locust’ was not divided into /xb/ /a/ /q/ /o/ as the syllabus and the literature prescribe (see Figure 4.1, 4.2, and 4.3). Phoneme segmentation activities of these kinds enhance children’s reading skills (Justice et al., 2010; Shapiro & Solity, 2008). However, as can be observed in the above lesson presentation, the phoneme segmentation is not segmented according to the grade 1 syllabus (MoE Ethiopia, 2013) and the early grade literature by National Reading Panel (US) et al. (2000) and Schuele and Boudreau (2008).

The incompleteness of components of phonological awareness

An incomplete description of phonological awareness in the textbook was reported in the result section. Regarding phoneme isolation, the textbook must provide individual sounds in a given word. In the current textbook, however, only the given sound was represented as the /d/ sound in the word *maido* ‘ox’, the /ii/ sound in the word *miise* ‘cow’, and the /xb/ sound in the word *xbago* ‘locust’ /xb/. The presentation of individual sounds helps children to easily recognize individual sounds and words as was shown in the work of Wessels (2011). The practice observed in the textbook is contrary to the existing literature in which the subdivision of a word into individual sounds is strongly recommended (cf. National Reading Panel (US) et al., 2000; Schuele & Boudreau, 2008).

For phoneme identification, the lesson should include an activity that asks children to identify similar phonemes in different words. For example, it should entail questions like what sound is the same in the words *let*, *love*, and *lap*? In the given textbook, the phoneme /ii/ was represented in various words in mid-word position as in the words *miise* ‘cow’, *siila* ‘seedling of enset’, and *tiire* ‘squatting’. The small gap observed in this representation was that the sound /ii/ did not occur in the initial and final positions of several words (see Figure 4.2). A similar finding was reported by Bulman (2021), and it was noted that incomplete phoneme identification in early educational material makes children’s reading abilities difficult.

Omission of components of phonological awareness

Several components of the phonological awareness activities were omitted from the textbook for first-grade students. Specifically, the result of the textbook evaluation showed that syllable (blending and deletion), rhyme (identity, recognition, and production), and alliteration activities were not integrated into the textbook. This situation, however, contradicts the current literature which demonstrates the importance of familiarizing children with rhyming and alliteration and initial and final sounds for their success in preschool and early grade education (Turan & Gul, 2008). Moreover, onset-rimes (isolation, identification, and categorization) are important skills as units in preschool

and early grade as shown in the work of Goswami (2001). However, such activities were omitted from the student textbook under study.

Phoneme manipulation activities (categorization, blending, deletion, addition, and substitution) are reported to be very important to recognize individual sounds in a word in previous works as in Hayward, Phillips, and Sych (2014). However, the current student textbook lacked these key components of the phonological awareness tasks. Also, the result of a study showed that there is a serious discrepancy between teacher practice and textbooks designed for classroom teaching in Ethiopia, as in Fitsume (2020:66). The inclusion of phoneme manipulation in preschool reading materials and textbooks for preschool children is commonly suggested in early childhood education (cf. Piasta, 2016). Nonetheless, graded reading material is one of the teaching materials that can be used by teachers to teach reading (Ali & Saiden, 2015). The results of the study showed that there is a lack of availability and quality of teaching and learning materials related to the components of phonological awareness in the first grade. This showed that teachers' classroom practice lacks appropriate strategies and phonological awareness of the content to develop reading skills. A study also indicates that the practice of the curriculum led to serious malfunctions due to missing content (Kablan, Topan, & Erkan, 2013).

Conclusions and recommendations

The findings of this study showed that the first-grade Koorete textbook does not reach the minimum learning competence (MLC) specified in the language curriculum as it did not integrate the standard teaching contents and many reading activities of PA. The analysis also revealed that some components of phonological awareness activities, namely syllable isolation, and syllable segmentation were inappropriately displayed in the textbook. Moreover, incomplete descriptions of phonemes (isolation, identification, and segmentation) and activities were incorporated in the grade 1 textbook of the Koorete Language. It fails to present appropriate lessons and activities throughout the chapter to help children learn to read. If teacher skills or classroom resources are insufficient to support these children's acquisition of PA skills, the children will not achieve the expected reading development (Hayward, Phillips, & Sych, 2014:20).

Further, other components of PA, such as syllable (blending, deletion), rhyme (identity, recognition, production), alliteration (initial & final sound), onset-rime (isolation, identification, categorization), and phoneme (blending, deletion, addition, substitution) activities, were omitted from the textbook. Gaps were, thus, observed in the alignment of the textbook with the components of PA activities with the corresponding syllabus and early grade reading literature given in MoE Ethiopia (2013), NRP (2000), and Schuele and Boudreau (2008). Generally, the textbook is failed in giving an appropriate presentation of lessons, a complete description as well an integration of key components of phonological awareness.

The outcome of this research is of great interest to curriculum designers and early grade material developers who are interested in improving the quality of reading materials, particularly to improve learners' phonological awareness. These findings point to the need to revise the first-grade Koorete textbook to address components of PA skills that are consistent with children's reading development. To ensure the quality of the textbook, the relevant stakeholders, such as the Ethiopian Ministry of Education, Amaro Special Woreda Educational Office, SNNPR, and District Education Agencies should select appropriate experts and trained mother tongue teachers in early literacy, curriculum designing, and textbook development, particularly in disadvantaged Ethiopian languages like Koorete. Moreover, developers of reading materials for early grade children need to be aware of these limitations of the textbook and take them into account when they prepare new material or revise the existing one.

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